

The 28-Day CES Compliance Audit

Find the CES Gaps in Your REC Before ESV Does

A practical self-audit workbook for Victorian Registered Electrical Contractors

- 5-point pre-audit checklist • Penalty exposure worksheet
- Common CES gaps mapped • ESV response playbook

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Why This Matters

If you issue Certificates of Electrical Safety (CES) in Victoria, this workbook is the most important 20 minutes you spend on compliance this year.

In 2026, Energy Safe Victoria has increased audit activity across the electrical contracting sector — with a specific focus on solar and battery installations. A routine compliance audit can uncover multiple CES failures, and the combined penalty exposure for even a small number of late or missing certificates can reach **\$15,000–\$30,000** in a single inspection.

This workbook walks you through a 5-point self-audit that mirrors what ESV checks in a first-stage review. Run it against your current CES record and see where your gaps are — before ESV does.

The 5-Point CES Self-Audit

Print this section and work through each point against your current CES record.

1	Lodgement Timeline Check	Pull your last 10 CES. For each one, note the date the work was completed and the date the CES was lodged. Any gap over 28 days is a compliance breach. Any gap over 28 days where you cannot produce the CES record is an audit risk.
2	Certificate Completeness	Check that each CES includes: contractor name and REC number, installation address, description of work, date of completion, and signature. Missing fields = invalid CES in ESV's view.
3	Equipment Documentation	For solar/battery installations: does the CES reference panel brand, model, quantity, inverter details, and system capacity? AS/NZS 5033 compliance evidence should accompany the certificate.
4	DNSP Notification	For grid-connected solar: was the DNSP separately notified? The CES alone does not satisfy network notification requirements. Check distributor rules for your area (CitiPower, Powercor, AusNet, United Energy, Jemena).
5	Record Keeping	Do you have a backup copy of every CES lodged? ESV recommends keeping records for 7 years. If your ESV Connect account were inaccessible tomorrow, could you reconstruct your compliance history?

Penalty Exposure Worksheet

How to use this worksheet: For each violation type in the left column, count how many instances apply to your REC in the past 12 months. Multiply by the low and high dollar ranges for that violation, then total your exposure at the bottom. Be conservative — ESV audits use the high end.

If you don't know how many instances you have, start with "1" as a minimum and run the 5-point self-audit (previous section) to get accurate numbers.

Violation	Per Instance (Proactive)	Per Instance (Audit Discovered)	Count	Your Low Risk	Your High Risk
1. CES lodged 29+ days late	\$150–\$300	\$300–\$600	___	\$___	\$___
2. CES never lodged at all	\$500–\$1,500	\$2,000–\$5,000	___	\$___	\$___
3. Incomplete / invalid CES	N/A — re-lodge	\$500–\$2,000	___	\$___	\$___
4. Missing DNSP notification	Possible recall	\$1,000–\$3,000	___	\$___	\$___
5. No backup CES records	Reconstruction	\$500–\$1,500	___	\$___	\$___
TOTAL EXPOSURE	—	—	___	\$___	\$___

Multiply "Count" (column 4) by the dollar range to calculate your total. The "Audit Discovered" column applies ESV's escalation multiplier — penalties discovered during a formal audit are typically 2-3x higher than those you self-report proactively.

Tip: If your total High Risk exposure exceeds \$5,000, escalate this workbook to a compliance professional before ESV escalates it for you.

Your Risk Level	Exposure Range	Action Required
■ Low	\$0–\$1,000	Monitor — run quarterly self-audit
■ Moderate	\$1,000–\$5,000	Fix identified gaps within 30 days
■ High	\$5,000–\$15,000	Engage compliance professional now
■ Critical	\$15,000+	Stop — seek legal advice before ESV contacts you

Tip: Print this worksheet, fill in your actual numbers, and keep it in your REC compliance folder as evidence of proactive self-auditing — it helps your position if ESV ever comes asking.

3 Common CES Gaps (and How to Fix Them)

Gap 1: Solar & Battery Installations

The #1 CES compliance gap in 2026. Solar and battery installations involve both electrical work (requiring a CES) and STC creation (requiring CEC documentation). Many installers confuse the two processes or assume the CEC paperwork satisfies the CES requirement. **It does not.** The CES is a separate legal obligation under the Electricity Safety Act 1998.

Fix: Create a job template that auto-generates a CES checklist for every solar/battery job, completed before the install team leaves site.

Gap 2: Switchboard Upgrades

Switchboard upgrades are high-risk for CES gaps because they are often "add-on" work — a customer asks for a switchboard replacement during a solar or EV install, and the electrician treats it as an extension rather than a separate notifiable installation. The CES requirement applies to the switchboard work independently.

Fix: Always issue a separate CES for switchboard upgrade work, even when part of a larger scope.

Gap 3: Emergency Call-Outs

Emergency call-outs — after-hours faults, temporary repairs — are the most commonly overlooked CES triggers. An electrician attends a residential after-hours fault, replaces a damaged switchboard component, and leaves without issuing a CES because it was "just a quick fix." Under Victorian regulations, if work involved alteration to fixed wiring, a CES is required.

Fix: Train every technician: any work involving fixed wiring — even emergency repairs — requires a CES. Add a CES reminder to your emergency call-out workflow.

Gap Action Checklist

Tick each item as you implement it. Keep this as evidence of proactive compliance.

	Action	Done	Date
■	Create solar/battery CES job template in your system	■	___
■	Train installers: separate CES for switchboard work	■	___
■	Add CES reminder to emergency call-out workflow	■	___
■	Set up quarterly self-audit reminder	■	___
■	Export all CES records from ESV Connect for backup	■	___
■	Tag each job in your system with "CES required" flag	■	___
■	Assign a compliance lead on your team	■	___

Lodgement Workflow: The 48-Hour Rule

The regulation says 28 days. The best-practice target for avoiding audit flags: **48 hours**.
ESV cross-references job completion dates against CES lodgement dates. A pattern of CES lodged at 25-28 days — even within the legal window — flags your REC for "late lodgement clustering" and increases audit probability. The 48-hour rule eliminates this risk entirely.

CES Lodgement Timeline

Day 0–2	Target: 48-Hour Rule	✓ No audit flag
Day 0–28	Legal: 28-Day Deadline	✓ Compliant
Day 29+	Breach: Late Lodgement	■ Infringement risk
Day 90+	Escalation: Audit Trigger	■ Full compliance review

48-Hour Workflow: Step by Step

1	Job Complete	Technician marks job complete on-site via mobile app. Notes: time, date, work description.
2	CES Data Entry	Admin logs into ESV Connect. Enters: REC number, customer address, job description, equipment details, date completed.
3	Review & Attach	Technician reviews the CES entry for accuracy. Attach compliance photos (switchboard, solar array, etc.) to the job record.
4	Submit to ESV	Submit via ESV Connect. Download the confirmation receipt. Attach receipt to job file.
5	DNSP Notify	For solar jobs: notify the relevant distributor (CitiPower, Powercor, AusNet, United Energy, Jemena). File the notification reference.
6	Archive	Save CES confirmation PDF in job record. Back up ESV Connect portal data quarterly. Keep records for 7 years.

The ESV Response Playbook

If you receive a compliance notice from ESV, follow these steps in order.

Step 1: Read the Notice Carefully

ESV compliance notices specify the alleged breach, the period under review, and the documents required. Response window: typically 14–28 days. Do not respond until you have gathered all requested information — a rushed partial response triggers escalation.

Step 2: Run Your Own Audit First

Before submitting anything to ESV, run the 5-point self-audit (page 3) against the period under review. Identify every gap, not just the ones ESV asked about. They may expand the scope if they find issues beyond the original notice.

Step 3: Prepare a Remediation Plan

For each gap, document: what went wrong, when it was fixed, and the system change that prevents recurrence. ESV responds favourably to RECs who demonstrate proactive remediation — even if the initial breach was significant.

Step 4: Get Professional Support

If penalty exposure exceeds \$5,000 or involves potential licence conditions, engage a compliance lawyer or industry association rep before responding. MEA (masterelectricians.com.au) and NECA (neca.asn.au/vic) both offer compliance support to members.

Step 5: Submit a Complete Response

Your response should include: the completed notice, your self-audit results, your remediation plan, and evidence of system changes implemented. Submit before the deadline — extensions are rarely granted.

Resources

- Energy Safe Victoria — esv.vic.gov.au
- ESV Connect portal — e-services.esv.vic.gov.au
- Master Electricians Australia — masterelectricians.com.au
- NECA Victoria — neca.asn.au/vic
- TradieAutomate CES Guide — tradieautomate.com/blog/certificate-electrical-safety-ces-victoria-guide-2026/

Disclaimer

This e-book is a practical compliance guide, not legal advice. Regulatory requirements and penalty amounts change over time. Always verify current requirements directly with Energy Safe Victoria or your legal advisor before taking compliance action. Current as of October 2026.